



THE STATUS GUIDE · VOLUME I

# 5 Suit Mistakes

That Lower Your Status — and How to Fix Them. A short field guide for men who refuse to look ordinary.

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## Mistake #1 — Wearing the Wrong Shoulder Width

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The shoulder seam should land precisely at the edge of your natural shoulder bone. A millimetre past it and the jacket reads off-the-rack and tired. A millimetre before it and you look constricted and apologetic.

**The fix:** in any well-made suit, raise both arms forward. The shoulder seam should rotate as a clean hinge, not crumple or pull at the bicep. If it crumples, the shoulder is too wide. If the bicep pulls, the armhole is too low. Both kill your silhouette.

## Mistake #2 — Trouser Break That Drowns Your Shoes

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Pooled fabric over the shoe is the single most common reason a suit looks lazy in photographs. It shortens the leg line, breaks the vertical and ages the wearer by a decade.

**The fix:** a quarter break or no break at all. The trouser hem should kiss the top of the shoe with one soft horizontal crease — no more. For dress trousers, a 1.5 cm slant hem (longer at the back) elongates the leg dramatically without looking cropped.

## Mistake #3 — A Jacket That's Too Long

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If your jacket covers the seat of your trousers entirely, it's too long. The classical proportion: the jacket should end at the curve where your fingers naturally curl when your arms hang at your sides — covering roughly 75% of the seat, no more.

**The fix:** a longer jacket flatters no one. It compresses height, shortens the leg and removes presence. Most off-the-rack jackets are cut 2–3 cm too long. A skilled tailor can shorten by up to 4 cm without compromising the pocket placement.

## Mistake #4 — The Wrong Color Against Your Skin

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Power isn't in the suit, it's in the contrast between the suit and your face. Get the contrast wrong and the suit will outshine you. Get it right and you'll appear instantly more authoritative.

**The fix:** high-contrast complexions (dark hair, fair skin) command crisp navy, charcoal and midnight. Medium-contrast complexions (warm brown hair, warm skin) flatter best in browns, taupes, warm greys and earth tones. Low-contrast complexions (blond, fair) glow in soft greys, pale blues and beige — but should avoid jet black, which will dominate the face.

## Mistake #5 — A Tie That Outshouts the Suit

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The tie is supporting cast, never lead. A loud tie against a quiet suit makes the eye rest on the tie, not on you. The most powerful men in any room wear ties that vanish into the composition — they make the wearer the subject.

**The fix:** the tie should be one register darker or quieter than the shirt, in a texture (grenadine, knit, cashmere) rather than a printed pattern. The tie should match the trouser tone, not the jacket. And the knot should be one notch smaller than your collar opening — no gaps, no strain.

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## Ready to begin?

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